Franziska: A Silent Protest against Sterilization

By Ina R. Friedman

Everything was done legally. First a law was passed to remove the "undesirable" elements from public service. Jews lost their jobs as teachers, civil servants, and doctors in hospitals. This decree was followed in 1933 by the "Law for the Prevention of Offspring with Hereditary Defects." It required that persons who were blind, deaf, physically or mentally handicapped, or were alcoholic be sterilized.

Teachers in schools for the deaf, who were themselves, hearing, turned over the names of their deaf pupils to the Nazi authorities. From 1934 to 1939, between 350,000 and 400,000 people lost their ability to have children in this unjust and unscientific program.

[Today] Hitler is dead and the Nazi regime is ancient history. But the laws for sterilization are still on the books of West Germany. Today there are people who say the Holocaust never happened, that it is only an "invention." But each law, each action affected an individual.

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INTRODUCTION

Franziska (Franny) Schwarz was blond, a German Aryan and . . . deaf. When she was sixteen, the Nazis knocked at her door. To Hitler, Jews and gypsies weren't the only "undesirables" Franziska:. A Silent Protest against Sterilization by Ina R. Friedman. It is time her voice is heard.

NOTE: Should be spoken (at least in part) with the affectation of a deaf person (ie Actress Marlee Matlin) Being able to use sign language would also be a plus for this selection!

I never saw anything wrong with being deaf. My younger sister, Theresa, and most of my friends were deaf. In deaf school, the teachers go mad if I signed. They wanted me to read lips and to use my voice. I got so tired of watching the teacher's lips. I couldn't look away for a minute. It was even harder when she tried to teach me to say the letters correctly. The teacher put a strip of paper in front of my lips. *(with a German accent)* "To make the B sound, purse your lips and blow just enough to make the paper quiver. To make a P, blow a little harder and make the paper shake." Day after day the teacher drilled me.

When I was fourteen, Hitler took over Germany. But I couldn't hear the radio, so I never got excited about Hitler. Not until the trouble started in 1935. I came home and found Mother crying. "What's the matter?" I signed.

She handed me the letter that read, "Frau Schwarz and her daughter Franziska are to come to the health office to arrange for their sterilization. Heil Hitler."

"I won't go," I cried. "I want to be able to have babies." The previous year, I had met a boy I like, Christian Mikus. As a child, he had had scarlet fever and lost his hearing in one ear. Whenever he saw children playing, he'd smile and sign, "One day, we will have children, too."

"Father looked sad. "If you don't go, the police will drag you to the hospital."

I screamed all the way . . The nurse locked me in a room with two other deaf teenagers. The three of us cried all night. When the nurse came to give us tranquilizers, I tried to fight her off. She held me down and gave me the injection. In the morning, I woke up in a room full of beds. My stomach hurt. I touched the bandages and started to cry. The nurse who brought me water was crying too. "I'm sorry, there's nothing I could do to help you. With Hitler, you have to be quiet." Her finger pointed to the portrait of Hitler handing over the bed. She tapped her temple with her finger, to indicate, "He's crazy."

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I had so much pain, I couldn't go to work. I asked the public health insurance office for the standard sick pay.

"Why should you get sick pay?" the social worker sneered. "You can have all the fun you want. You don't have to worry about getting pregnant."

When Christian came to the house, I started to cry. "The doctors sterilized me. I guess you won't want to be my boyfriend anymore." Christian made the sign for love. "Whatever happens, we'll be together. As soon as you're twenty-one, we'll get married."

In 1938, in spite of being sterilized, I missed my period. My mother was out of town helping a sick relative. When she returned, a few months later, she saw my swollen stomach. "How could you do this?"

"Please, please, don't be angry. We want a baby so much. I was afraid I'd never have one. Now Christian and I can get married."

"All right, but I want to be sure you have proper care. I want you to go to a gynecologist."

The gynecologist who examined me was very jolly. "Congratulations. The Fuehrer wants every young girl to have a baby." Then I saw my mother say, "I'm surprised Franziska got pregnant. She's been sterilized."

Within a few days, I had a letter from the health office. "Fraulein Schwarz Is to come to the Women's Hospital for an examination."

I took off my clothes and went into the examining room. The doctor felt my stomach. "Yes, you're pregnant. The pregnancy appears normal. Go into the other room."

The doctor pushed me inside the changing room and locked the door. I looked out the window. I was on the fifth floor, too far to jump. I hid behind the door. When the nurse brought lunch, I escaped and ran toward the stairs. All the nurses ran after me. They caught me and locked me in the room.

For three days, I lay there, biting my nails and screaming. Then [on the 4th day] the nurse dragged me by the hair into the hall and put me in a room with barred windows. I

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banged on the wall so they would let me out. The nurse shoved me into bed and gave me an injection. I woke up just as the stretcher was being wheeled into the operating room. There was a big tray next to the operating table. My baby is going to be on that tray, I thought, instead of inside me. "No, No," I tried to shout. . . . Christian!

Christian didn't know where I was. Every day, he went to my house, but my mother wouldn't open the door. Finally my mother told him "Franziska is in the Women's Hospital. They took the baby."

When I woke up from a nap, I saw Christian standing next to the bed. My face was so white he dropped the flowers he had brought me. "Franziska, I'm sorry they took the baby. But we'll still get married. We can't stop Hitler, but he can't stop us from loving each other."

The nurse handed me a notice when I left the hospital. "You are to return to this hospital within 10 weeks to be sterilized." I started to cry. "It's hopeless. I won't go. It's too painful. I'll hide in a convent until the war is over. Then we can get married and have children."

"No," Christian said. "The Nazis will find you. They'll take you and do it whether you want it or not. Hitler is winning the war."

My Uncle Karl wrote to the judges for a hearing. My mother, my father, and all his brothers went to the court. The judges refused to change the order. My uncle's face got very red. "God damn Hitler! How can he do this to a young girl?"

The judge stood up. His face got so red and twisted he looked like the gargoyle in the corner of the church. "Arrest this man. He has slandered the Fuehrer."

His brothers tried to get him released. They promised he would join the army and fight for the Fuehrer. The Nazis wouldn't listen. They beheaded Uncle Karl and sent the family the bill for the executioner. It was a horrible time for me and my family.

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POST SCRIPT: Franziska Schwarz Mikus survived the war and she and Christopher were married. They moved to Munich and Franziska has been active in promotion arts and crafts among the deaf, serving as secretary to three different organizations. Christian died a few years ago. His death was mourned by the entire deaf community of Germany and Europe. He had become well known for his coaching abilities and his soccer team had participated in the international deaf games.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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